

Understanding Adverbs: Always

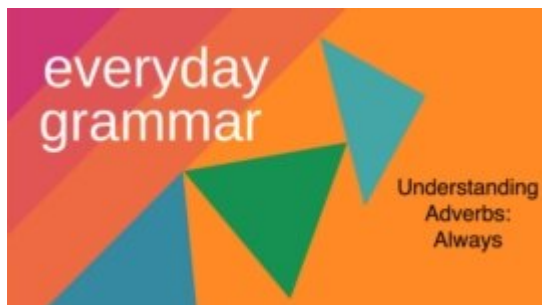
The film "Casablanca" is one of the most famous American movies of all time.

At the end of the film, the actor Humphrey Bogart says a heartbreaking **farewell** to the woman he loves.

Bergman: But what about us?

Bogart: We'll always have Paris.

Besides affecting one's emotions, this movie **scene** can teach you a lot about English grammar. It can show you how English speakers use **adverbs** in a sentence.



Understanding Adverbs: Always

In our program today, we explore a single word: always. We will discover why Bogart said his famous line the way he did.

Do not worry. Unlike the ending of "Casablanca," we will not leave you in tears!

Adverbs and Movability

In other Everyday Grammar stories, we explored adverbs.

Adverbs are words that change the meaning of a verb, adjective, or sentence. They are often used to show time, place, or a way of doing things.

Adverbs are often movable. They can appear at the beginning, middle, or end of a sentence.

Consider these examples:

Occasionally I eat seafood.

I **occasionally** eat seafood.

I eat seafood **occasionally**.

In this example, the adverb *occasionally* appears in three different places in the sentence. The placement of the adverb does not change the meaning. All three sentences have the same meaning. Most English speakers would not think it strange if you used any one of these sentences.

Always is not as movable

What about the adverb *always*?

In general, the adverb *always* is not as movable as other kinds of adverbs – like the word *occasionally*.

You will not often hear an English speaker use *always* at the beginning or the end of a sentence.

Most often, you will hear *always* in the middle of the sentence, before the verb it is **modifying**.

In some cases, you might hear it at the beginning of a sentence – when giving an order or command, for example.*

Or you might hear it at the end of a sentence, but usually only in an artistic setting: a poetry reading or a musical performance, for example.

But the central point is this: in speaking and in writing, *always* does not move its position as often as other adverbs.

So, if you were to take our example sentence, "I eat seafood," and use the adverb *always*, you could say, "I *always* eat seafood."

Always generally is found after "BE" verbs and **auxiliary** verbs, but before other verbs.

You will find this structure in many popular films. Consider this famous line from "A Streetcar Named Desire:"

"Whoever you are, I have always depended on the kindness of strangers."

A Streetcar Named Desire, 1951

In the example, *always* appears after the auxiliary verb, *have*, and just before the main verb, *depended*.

This same idea is true of Bogart's famous line from "Casablanca,"

"We'll *always* have Paris."

"We'll" is a short way to say, "we will." *Always* appears after the auxiliary verb, *will*, and before the main verb, *have*.

Emphasized always

You might think that our story about the word *always* ends here, but it does not!

English speakers can also change the meaning of *always*.

When you hear or read the adverb *always* in its usual position, before the verb it is modifying. It generally has the meaning of *habitually*.

However, sometimes you will hear English speakers **emphasize** the word *always*.

In this case, the meaning of the sentence has changed. Think back to our example sentence: "I *always* eat seafood."

This sentence means that you usually eat seafood – perhaps when you go to a restaurant.

If the speaker says, "I **ALWAYS** eat seafood," with the emphasis on the word "always," then the speaker is expressing annoyance. Perhaps the speaker is angry that another person – a close friend,

for example – did not remember they like to eat seafood when they go out to dinner.

Here is another example: you hear a child say, "My father always works late on Thursdays." This sentence uses the adverb *always* to express a habitual or common action.

However, if you hear the child say, "My dad ALWAYS works late on Thursdays," then you know that the child is unhappy with the father's work schedule.

What can you do?

So, now you know that if Bogart had used the emphasized *always* in the film *Casablanca*, the ending of the film would have been very different.

The next time you are listening or speaking, try to pay attention to the placement of the word *always*. Then, try to identify if it is emphasized or not. This will help you understand the speaker's feelings.

Remember: English does not always communicate meaning through grammar. Emphasis plays an important role in showing the meaning of a sentence.

With practice, you, too, will be able to use *always* like a native speaker!

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And I'm John Russell.

John Russell wrote this story for Learning English. George Grow was the editor.

We want to hear from you. Write to us in the Comments Section.

*[Always can begin imperative sentences](#). Here is an example: Always wear your seatbelt.

Words in this Story

farewell – *n.* an act of leaving

adverb – *n.* a word that describes a verb, an adjective, another adverb, or a sentence and that is often used to show time, manner, place, or degree

occasionally – *adv.* sometimes but not often

emphasize – *v.* to place emphasis on (something)

auxiliary verb – *n.* a verb (such as *have*, *be*, *may*, *do*, *shall*, *will*, *can*, or *must*) that is used with another verb to show the verb's tense, to form a question, etc.

modify – *v.* to limit or describe the meaning of (a word or group of words)

scene – *n.* a part of a play, movie, story, etc., in which a particular action or activity occurs